



PARTY LEADERS (FAR LEFT) AT THE OPENING OF A THEME PARK STARTED BY A CPI(M) SUBSIDIARY

Photographs by S.K. MOHAN

Ramesh Chennithala, president, Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC). He says the fact that for the first time even Politburo members become accused in corruption cases like the Lavalin scam shows the decline in the party's principles. Constructions worth about Rs 100 crore have been launched by the CPI(M) and its front organisations in the last four years of power alone. Prominent among them are the Rs 13-crore complex of the party backed *Kairali* television channel and Rs 10-crore headquarters of party mouthpiece *Deshabhimani*—both in capital, Thiruvananthapuram.

It's not just party old timers who are horrified. The mangroves and water parks have invited flak from environmentalists, including the Kerala Sasthra Sahithya Parishad, a promi-

nent Left-leaning green group. The water park is accused of guzzling the scant water resources while the mangroves project, on the banks of river Valapattanam, is seen as challenging the ecologically fragile mangroves. The swank twin towers of nine storeys each, inaugurated recently for the *Kairali* TV, have turned rivals green with envy. Opposition leader Oommen Chandy, who was present at the inauguration along with Defence Minister A.K. Antony, said tongue firmly in cheek: "Hope the Congress-owned *Jaihind* channel too moves to its own premises soon. It would be a much smaller place". Hardly a month later a new six-storey headquarters for *Deshabhimani* was inaugurated by CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat. Apparently a bit embarrassed

by the extravagant mansion, Karat said, "Now we have such big buildings for the party paper. But never forget the humble beginnings we had when *Deshabhimani* was launched long ago with paltry contributions like a calf or a sack full of rice by ordinary people".

Nearly 25 more multi-storey constructions are underway now in different parts of the state for party committees and its front organisations of women, youth, students, teachers or government employees. Among the big structures dotting the Thiruvananthapuram skyline are the AKG Centre, the party headquarters, a multi-storey apartment complex for party leaders and the sprawling EMS Academy, a residential campus for party education.

The party claims that all the money